

# The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle called The Seven Buddhas

Ārya Sapta Buddhaka nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra · Toh 512 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བ་དྲུག་པ་ཞེས་བུ་བྱ་བ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ།

The Seven Buddhas, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Sapta Buddhaka Nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa sangs rgyas bdun pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a Mahāyāna sūtra that recounts a teaching delivered by the Blessed One at the summit of Mount Tise, in the presence of a great assembly of monks and bodhisattvas including Maitreya, Ākāśagarbha, and Samantabhadra. As its title indicates, the text concerns the seven buddhas, a traditional grouping of awakened beings that spans the distant past to the historical Buddha Śākyamuni, and it belongs to the devotional and narrative dimension of Mahāyāna literature. It is Toh 512 in the Kangyur, catalogued among the general sūtra collections of that canon.

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Revised and settled definitively.

In the language of India: Ārya Sapta Buddhaka nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra.

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle called The Seven Buddhas.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling at the summit of Mount Tise, in the divine abode, at no great distance from the hermitage of the sages. He was accompanied by a great Saṅgha of approximately five hundred monks, and by five hundred bodhisattvas, namely: the great bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-Kindness), the great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha (Essence of Space), Samantabhadra, Anantapuṣpa (Flowers Without Limit), Samantapuṣpa (Flowers Everywhere), and many other bodhisattvas who were all bound for awakening by a single further birth. Together with these, they were all in attendance.

Then the Blessed One, in that very forest at the summit of the mountain, beheld a monk who had been seized by a spirit, writhing naked and without clothing, arms raised, weeping as he sat there. At that, the great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and, facing in the direction of the Blessed One, joined his palms in reverence and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One,

what is this piercing cry resounding through the midst of the sky, and who is this monk, naked and without clothing, arms raised in distress?"

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to the great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, this one has been struck by illness. And that other one there has likewise been struck by illness."

Then the great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha addressed the Blessed One with these words: "May the Blessed One please teach, please proclaim, the knowledge mantra that utterly pacifies all illness and repels all spirits."

Thereupon the Blessed One performed a buddha emanation, and from that act six Tathāgatas appeared in the sky. The seventh is the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni himself. Then the Tathāgata Vipāśyin (All-Seeing), dwelling in the sky above, proclaimed these mantra foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the utter pacification of all illness, and for the repulsion of all spirits:

Namo Buddhāya. Namō Dharmāya. Namaḥ Saṃghāya. Tadyathā: Oṃ hala hala, hila hīlāya, namo jaganmitranāya, namo namaḥ svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Vipāśyin spoke thus to the great bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, whoever bears this knowledge mantra, reads it, or brings it to fullness — no weapon shall be able to harm their body; they shall not die by the illness-suffering of water or fire; they shall not meet their end by untimely death; even if they consume poison, it shall be to them as food; if food and drink are recited over seven times and then consumed, harm from enemies shall not arise; they shall not be struck by any illness; they shall live long; they shall retain what they hear; they shall behold the forms of the seven Tathāgatas. Into an ear pierced by a weapon, the mantra should be recited and sesame butter applied. For those afflicted with leprosy and swelling diseases, if they are given butter mixed with sesame oil, blue lotus, cardamom, and deodar cedar, all illnesses shall be healed. It may be applied to all activities as well."

Then the Tathāgata Śikhin (Crest-Bearing), dwelling in the sky above, for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the utter pacification of all illness, and for the repulsion of all spirits —

declared these mantra foundations for the repulsion of all spirits. Homage to the Buddha. Homage to the Dharma. Homage to the Saṅgha. Oṃ paca paca pācaya pācaya sarva bhūtānāṃ chindaya kīlaya bara vidyānāṃ svāhā.

Ākāśagarbha (Space-Matrix), for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the utter pacification of all illness, for the reversal of meditation faults and all bad dreams, and for the prevention of untimely death — this essence has been proclaimed by many hundreds of thousands of millions of buddhas, and I too now set it forth. Ākāśagarbha, whoever holds this, my essence, in mind three times daily, harm from others shall not arise for that person. While sleeping, they shall behold the forms of the Tathāgatas in their dreams. They shall not die a bad death. Passing from this world, they shall meet the Tathāgatas face to face and shall please them.

Now, the other ritual procedures of this teaching are as follows. For all illnesses, one should bind with cord. For ailments arising from compounded causes, one should recite the mantra over fresh butter and administer it. One should bind the directions with water. One should protect oneself with cord. For spirit-afflictions of children, one should apply a blue cord. Into an ear pierced by a weapon, the mantra should be recited seven times. For other cases as well, one should apply it according to one's own understanding.

Then all the Tathāgatas who protect, dwelling in the sky above, for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the utter pacification of all illness, and for the repulsion of all spirits, declared these mantra foundations. Homage to the Buddha. Homage to the Dharma. Homage to the Saṅgha. Oṃ kala kala kili kili kulu kulu kulota sādhanānāṃ kuru sarva grahānāṃ svāhā.

Ākāśagarbha, these mantra foundations have been proclaimed by all the Tathāgatas of this Good Aeon — past, future, and present — and I too now set them forth. Ākāśagarbha, you should take up these mantra foundations. Whoever retains, recites, or fully masters them: their body shall not be harmed by weapons; they shall not be harmed by poison; they shall not be harmed by plant-poison; they shall not be struck by epidemic disease, by water, by untimely death, or by bad death — excepting only obscurations from karma accumulated in former lives. Whatever monk, nun, layman, or laywoman rises at dawn, washes their head, and recites this one hundred and eight times before a Tathāgata — all the karmic obscurations of that person shall be completely purified. Beings who bear hatred toward them, even kings, shall speak favorably of them first. All sentient beings shall come under their sway. In any situation of fear whatsoever, one should bring this to mind. In all situations of fighting, conflict, dispute, and contention, one should apply a white cord. For eye disease, one should make a cord from the wood of a milk-bearing tree and apply it to the ear. For one who wishes to make an army

invincible, one should perform a fire offering one hundred and eight times, feeding it rice-balls coated with yogurt and honey. Rājānāṃ rājamātrambā vaśīkaratu kāmēna. Using firewood from a milk-bearing tree to light the fire, one should perform a fire offering of sesame seeds one thousand times. For one who wishes to purify all the obscurations and non-virtues of oneself and all sentient beings, and to accomplish great splendor and a great mass of wealth, one should perform a fire offering of sesame seeds one thousand times, using firewood from a milk-bearing tree. For one who wishes to purify all non-virtue whatsoever, to accomplish all knowledge-mantras, and to purify oneself, one should use śuṭī, nala, kre, śirīṣa, bdellium resin, and

saffron, spikenard, indravāruṇī, the wood of the Bodhi tree, and mango shoots — with all of these one should perform an ablution. In the presence of a buddha image, one should fast for a single day and night and place a full vase upon the ground. In the month of Pisces, one should recite the heart of the mantra one thousand and eight times before the image of a buddha, and then perform the ablution.

For one who wishes to render poison harmless: one should name the person aloud and perform a fire offering of one hundred and eight khadira-wood skewers smeared with human filth in the presence of a buddha image — through this the poison will be rendered harmless. Applied likewise to all activities involving demons, protective spirits, wandering ghosts, and the like, one will come to dwell in wellbeing.

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Dispeller of Wrong Views, dwelling in the sky above, proclaimed these mantra foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illness, and for the turning back of all wandering spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Namaḥ Krakucchanda Tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya. Oṃ kaṭa kaṭa. Kaṭha kaṭha. Kiṭi kiṭi. Kiṭhi kiṭhi. Kiṭāpaya. Namaḥ svāhā.

The essence of space — the Tathāgata, Arhat, Perfectly Awakened Buddha Dispeller of Wrong Views — this essence, praised and rejoiced over by as many as the grains of sand of the Gaṅgā river, you should hold. Take it up, hold it, and when you have fully accomplished it, in future lives monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen who, in that time, have found faith in the Three Jewels, have bathed, and have made offerings to the Blessed One of flowers, incense, and fragrant substances, and who recite this mantra one hundred and eight

times, will come to abundance. They will remember their past lives for seven lifetimes. Among the gods they will attain the very greatness of gods. Or among humans they will become a wheel-turning king. Or again, if practiced in accordance with the ritual, that person will attain a final human birth, and passing from here will be reborn in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī.

In this very life as well, one who always recites it will be freed from all illness. One will hold what one hears. If one recites the mantra seven times over food and drink and then eats and drinks them, one will be freed from all illness. If one wishes to quench thirst, one should perform an ablution over all food one thousand and eight times. If a wound is cut, it should be treated with a copper needle. For one who wishes to be freed from all conflicts, disputes, and bondage — if one recites seven times, wealth will constantly increase as well, and one will also be freed from all obstructions and misleading spirits.

If one wishes to behold the Tathāgata, one should draw a maṇḍala in a clean spot at the edge of the world and burn agaru incense, recite one thousand and eight times, and then, turning one's head to face east, lie down to sleep — one will behold the Tathāgata. Whatever is held in the mind, all of it will be revealed. Span of life, strength, and all victories and defeats will also be revealed.

Then the Tathāgata Suvarṇamuni, dwelling in the sky above, proclaimed these mantra foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illness, and for the turning back of all wandering spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Namaḥ Kanakamunaye tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya. Tadyathā. Oṃ sara sara. Sara sara. Siri siri. Siri siri. Sirāya. Dhama dhama. Dhama dhama. Dhuma dhuma. Dhuma dhumāya namo namaḥ Kanakamunaye tathāgatāya arhate samyaksaṃbuddhāya svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Suvarṇamuni spoke thus to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, whoever holds this essence-dhāraṇī and continuously recites it will not encounter the danger of weapons, will not die by fire, by water, or by a landslide. All poisons will become as harmless as food. They will not die an untimely death. They will not die in misfortune. They will have long life and great prosperity. They will always encounter the Tathāgata and be blessed by the Tathāgata. If they recite it three times at the three times of day, all karmic obscurations accumulated in the past will be purified.

If one wishes to liberate others from illness, one should offer tormas cakes as generously as possible, fumigate with agaru incense, and then ritually wash all the food. For leprosy, swelling disease, and tumors of the liver, one should apply fine white garlic, mix it with honey, recite the dhāraṇī one thousand and eight times before the Blessed One the Buddha, and then apply it — all diseases of leprosy will be healed. On the fourth day, one should take a garland of fresh flowers, recite over it one thousand and eight times before the Blessed One the Buddha, and bind it around the person's head — the four-day fever will be healed. If one recites the dhāraṇī into an ear that has been pierced by a weapon, the wound will be freed from its affliction. For those whose bodies are seized by corruption, fumigate them with flowers that have been offered to a buddha. All these and similar activities are to be performed — this is what is called the accomplishment of all activities."

Then the Tathāgata Kāśyapa, dwelling in the sky above, proclaimed these mantra foundations for the benefit of all sentient beings, for the complete pacification of all illness, and for the turning back of all wandering spirits:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Oṃ hara hara. Hara hara. Ha ha ha. Namaḥ Kāśyapāya. Tathāgatāya. Arhate. Samyaksambuddhāya. Siddhayantu mantrapadāḥ svāhā.

Then the Tathāgata Kāśyapa spoke thus to the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, this essence-dhāraṇī has been proclaimed by as many buddhas, Blessed Ones, as there are grains of sand in thirty-two Ganges rivers. Ākāśagarbha, you too should hold this dhāraṇī and master it fully. Whoever holds it, recites it, masters it fully, and recites it three times each in the daytime and three times each at night — in brief, they will even behold the Tathāgata in dreams. All their karmic obscurations will be purified — with the sole exception of karma from the most distant past. This is to be applied to all activities as well.

For leprosy and flesh-rot and the like, one should recite over flowers offered to a buddha one thousand and eight times before the presence of the Buddha, then read the dhāraṇī over the patient and wash them with the water — they will be healed. For headache, one should place flowers offered to a buddha before the presence of a buddha and recite one thousand and eight times before the presence of the Buddha. This too is to be applied in all contexts."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, dwelling in the sky above, proclaimed these vidyā-mantras for the benefit of all sentient beings:

Namo buddhāya. Namō dharmāya. Namaḥ saṃghāya. Tadyathā. Ghume ghume. Mahāghume. Tale tale. Mahātale. Cale cale. Mahācale. Dhure dhure. Mahādhure. Tiri tiri. Mahātiri. Kili kili. Mahākili. Curu curu. Mahācuru. Mili mili. Mahāmili. Tili tili. Mahātili. Dhume dhume. Mahādhume. Cale cale. Mahācale. Khiri khiri. Mahākhiri. Cili cili.

Mahācili svāhā. Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, spoke these words to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha: "Ākāśagarbha, to cure diseases of the head, it is to be done with a sword and the palm of the hand. To dispel clouds, it is to be done with a twig of the karavīra plant. To purify poisons, it is to be done with water. The other activities are also to be performed accordingly. It is to be combined with the ritual of bathing. All the rites are to be applied in all contexts."

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One fell silent. The bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha, was filled with joy, and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle entitled The Seven Buddhas is now complete.

## Translator's Notes

- The text opens with a phrase indicating this is a revised and finalized recension. The Sanskrit title Ārya Sapta Buddhaka nāma Mahāyāna Sūtra corresponds to the Tibetan title given and is standard for this text.

The divine abode at the summit of Mount Tise refers to Mount Kailash, associated in this tradition with a celestial realm, not merely the physical peak.

Tathāgata Vipāśyin, rendered "All-Seeing," translates rnam par gzig (Skt. Vipāśyin), the first of the seven buddhas of antiquity. Tathāgata Śikhin, rendered "Crest-Bearing," translates gtsug tor can (Skt. Śikhin), the second of the seven. The text breaks off mid-sentence at the mention of Śikhin's mantra proclamation, which is where the supplied passage ends.

The medicinal ingredients listed — sna ma'i mar, ut+pa la sngon po, shu ti, and nye'u shing pa — are rendered respectively as sesame butter, blue lotus (Skt. utpala), cardamom (Skt. śuṭī / elā), and deodar cedar (Skt. devadāru). The identification of nye'u shing pa as deodar cedar is the standard Tibetan medical interpretation, though some editions read other plants.

- The passage contains several embedded Sanskrit mantras that are transliterated directly from the Tibetan; they are rendered as close phonetic equivalents of the underlying Sanskrit. The mantra phrase "Rājānāṃ rājamātrambā vaśīkaratu kāmēna" is left in Sanskrit transliteration as it appears to be a ritual formula within the larger mantra sequence, and its precise syntactic parsing is uncertain. The term rendered "fresh butter" for རྩུཏི་མུ་ translates literally as "first-extracted butter" or "new butter," meaning freshly churned butter; this is rendered idiomatically. The list of substances at the end is incomplete in the source passage as given; śuṭī is a rhizome, nala is a type of reed grass, kre is tentatively a grain

measure used here as a plant name, and śīrṣa is the Albizia tree; the final substance name is cut off.

- The name སུབ་རྣམ་མཁུ་ (literally "Golden Sage" or "Golden Muni") rendered as "Suvarṇamuni" follows the straightforward Sanskrit equivalent; this is one of the seven tathāgatas named in texts of this tradition, corresponding to the buddha Kanakamuni (Krakucchanda's successor in the standard list of seven buddhas), though here the Tibetan uses a distinct epithet for a separate invocation. The text appears to treat Suvarṇamuni and Kanakamuni as two distinct tathāgatas within the same series.

The phrase rendered "world-realm of Sukhāvātī" glosses སུཁ་འབྲུག་ཡུལ་ ("the world-realm of Bliss"), the standard Tibetan for Sukhāvātī.

- The passage lists the Tathāgata Kāśyapa as dwelling "above in the sky" and then delivering a mantra section, followed immediately by Śākyamuni doing the same. This mirrors the structure of the preceding Suvarṇamuni section translated earlier, as part of what appears to be a liturgical sequence of Tathāgatas each proclaiming mantras in turn.

The phrase rendered "with the sole exception of karma from the most distant past" translates the qualifying clause that distinguishes previously accumulated karmic obscurations in general from a residual category described as "prior karma" — a standard Buddhist caveat in dhāraṇī literature indicating that even the most powerful dhāraṇī does not override the ripening of the weightiest past actions already set in motion.

The healing applications described — garlic mixed with honey for leprosy, flower garlands for fever, fumigation with offered flowers for bodily corruption — are traditional Āyurvedic-inflected ritual remedies embedded in dhāraṇī sūtra literature and should be understood as ritual-medical instructions within that genre.

- The karavīra plant is the oleander, Nerium oleander, a plant well known in Indian ritual and medical contexts. The twig of this plant is used here as an implement for dispersing clouds, a relatively straightforward ritual application without doctrinal ambiguity. The name Ākāśagarbha means "Essence of Space" or "Womb of the Sky," rendered here by its Tibetan equivalent since no standard Sanskrit transliteration was given in the source at this juncture; consistency with prior usage is maintained.

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.